RELIGIOUS INSTITUTIONS AND THE RISE OF MORAL CITIZENSHIP IN TAUNGOO

The substantive analysis in this chapter is based on largely qualitative, ethnographic fieldwork conducted throughout 2015 in Taungoo, a town positioned on the inner border of areas administered directly and indirectly by the British during the colonial period. Independence bequeathed Taungoo a complex ethnic patchwork comprised of large Bamar Buddhist and Karen Christian communities, as well as sizeable Hindu and Muslim populations. As of 2015, the township has a population of around 160,000, split between twenty-three urban quarters and a series of semi-industrial and farmland areas around five kilometres from the centre of town. Community leaders from all major ethnic and religious groups claim that the township is around sixty per cent ethnically Bamar Buddhist, thirty per cent Karen Christian, and ten per cent 'other' including Shan, Muslim, Hindu and Sikh communities.

Since the liberalizing reforms of 2011, Taungoo has experienced the same blossoming of 'political' civil society as well as substantial growth in government expenditure at local levels. Political party offices have proliferated, with almost every ward and village sporting at least one or two prominent signboards of the NLD or various ethnic or special interest parties, along with USDP offices. However, this culture of formal democratic contestation is evolving amidst an already crowded organizational and ideational sphere defined by moral ideas and institutions of non-state welfare and reciprocity developed since the 1990s, which retain a substantial role in local infrastructures of care and communication.

In Taungoo's Buddhist community, a rich sociology of local welfare and 'traditional' civil society groups has developed at neighbourhood, village, and township levels, often with deep organizational or cosmological links to Buddhism. Many of these groups are the direct beneficiaries of support and legitimacy provided by local monks and abbots (*sayadaws*). For instance, a number of monasteries provide offices and support to lay medical clinics that provide discounted or free treatment both for monks and members of the general public. Local doctors and dozens of non-medical professionals offer their time on a weekly basis at these clinics, engaging in what is perceived as socially productive merit-making, referred to by the Pali-derived term *parahita*.[5] Other monasteries provide ambulances for transportation of critically ill patients from Taungoo General Hospital